FAMILY-03 | Therapist only - all age groups

Listening and validation without having to agree

1 | Purpose, fit and boundaries

Purpose of this unit

Practice making room for another person's experience while preserving the participant's voice and boundaries. The outcome is a brief statement of what was understood and a checking question, without requiring agreement or giving in.

Choice and adaptation

Choose this sheet following professional assessment and with consent. The person may skip questions, answer aloud, or choose another tool. This is proposed original material for review; it provides no score, diagnosis, or promise of an outcome.

Boundaries specific to this unit

Understanding a feeling does not approve harm or require reconciliation, touch, or contact. Do not ask a harmed person to justify the person who hurt them, or a child to calm an adult. Under threat or humiliation, do not use the exercise to continue an unsafe conversation.

Reusing existing material

FAMILY-02 clarifies needs and roles. Here, focus on listening and correcting understanding before solving a problem or choosing an agreement.

A fictional example for discussion

Fictional example: Amir thought his sister wanted advice. When he asks what would help, she explains that she wanted listening. He reflects the pressure she described and keeps advice for later if she asks.

> Draft for administrator review. Clinical review and final rights approval are still pending.

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Working together with the worksheet

2 | A conversation about one situation

Opening

Choose a situation the person wants to explore. It need not be the hardest situation. Check that the question is understood and the wording fits the person; their account comes before the therapist's interpretation.

1 | Question for discussion

What family experience would I like to understand better?

2 | Question for discussion

What was said, and what did I add from my assumptions?

3 | Question for discussion

How will I reflect the experience without justifying hurtful behavior?

4 | Question for discussion

What clarification question will allow correction?

5 | Question for discussion

How will I ask for room for my perspective too?

Closing

Summarize what became clearer and what remains open. Use the existing SES-S01 and SES-S02 for the session framework. There is no need to repeat an assessment or plan already recorded.

Possible difficulties

If wording sounds artificial, return to the participant's usual words. When there is no reciprocity or experience is repeatedly dismissed, examine the setting, not just listening skills.

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Adapting for four age groups

3 | Age is a starting point, not an assumption about ability

CH | Children, approximately ages 6 to 11

Choose a short, comfortable conversation, not an argument between adults. An adult models listening and is responsible for reciprocity; the child is not tested on precise emotion identification.

Offer one question at a time with little writing. Adult support must not replace the child's own voice.

TE | Adolescents, approximately ages 12 to 17

Allow the adolescent to disagree and keep details private. Do not turn validation of a parent into a requirement to admit the parent is right.

Agree in advance what will be shared and with whom, and explain the privacy limits in this setting. Do not promise absolute confidentiality.

AD | Adults

Adapt to participants' relationships and language. Explore power differences and room to speak; do not require mutual conversation when conditions do not allow it.

OA | Older adults

Offer time, pace, and a communication method according to the person's wishes. Do not interpret silence as agreement or answer for them; writing may help if preferred.

Offer reading support, time, and conversation according to preference. Choose help from another person together with the participant, respecting their privacy.

> Each age version needs its own review. Approval of one version does not automatically approve the others.

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Practice, review and next steps

4 | Shared choice and learning from the attempt

Before offering practice sheet P

Exchanging sentences can be practiced only in the session. Conversation with a relative is by choice and subject to safety; do not send a message or invite someone else without consent.

At the next session

Ask whether understanding became more accurate and there was room for both voices. Remaining disagreement is not a failure of listening.

Professional and technical records

Each version has a separate review record covering age suitability, originality, rights, and fictional filling. Reviewer and date fields remain blank until assigned. File checks or a code merge are not clinical approval. Clinical information stays only in the authorized setting, outside the code repository.

Background references

The following links were used for background only. Questions and adaptations were written afresh for the expansion plan; no questionnaire, scale, or protocol was copied. Adult sources do not validate the child versions. This material makes no claim about session count or treatment effectiveness.

www.nhs.uk/every-mind-matters/lifes-challenges/maintaining-healthy-relationships-and-mental-wellbeing/
www.unicef.org/eca/stories/how-communicate-effectively-your-young-child

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